

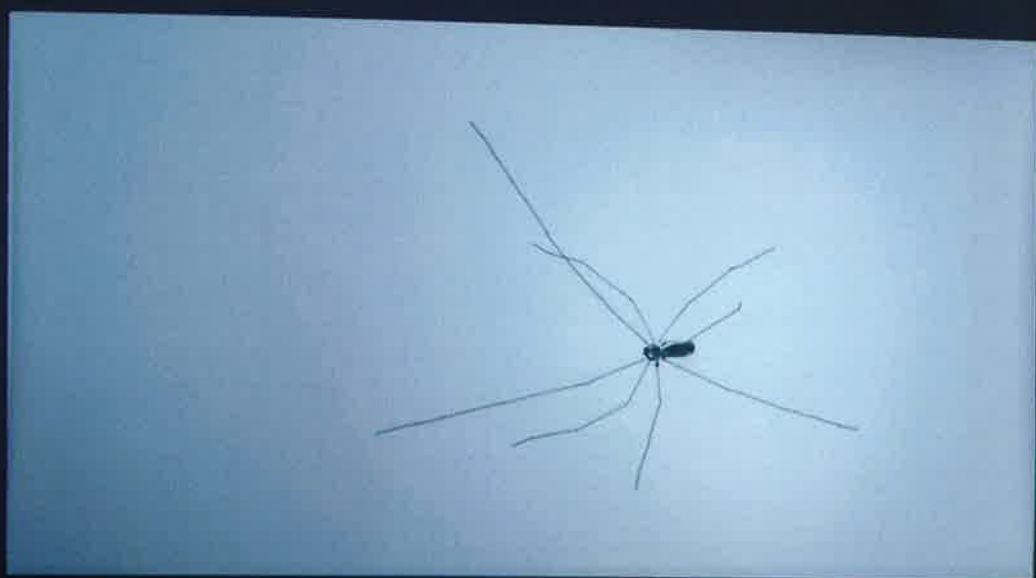
ECHO

THE ECHO

Although I am still alive

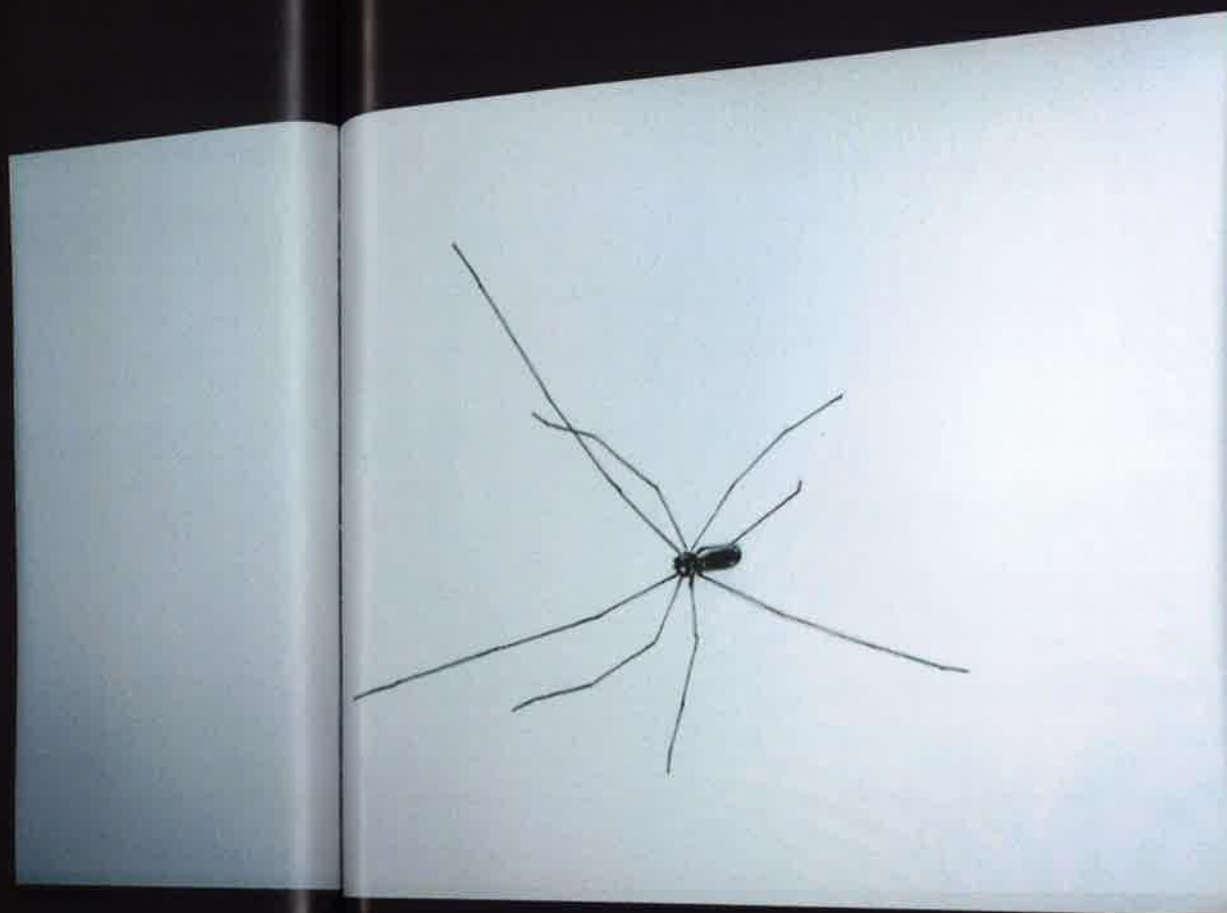
EXHIBITION OF
YOUNG JAPANESE ARTISTS

In Berlin



Artist Name :

Tabata Kouichi



A Revolt From Within The Structure – Form That Causes Repetition To Implode

Mori Keisuke

Art critic

REFERENCES

1: Ito, H., et al. (2010) *THE ECHO: AN EXHIBITION OF YOUNG JAPANESE ARTISTS* (exhibition catalogue), Tokyo: Magical, ARTROOM, p.16.

2: Agamben G., trans. Okaga, A & Taga, K. (2004) *Hirakare: Ningen to dobutsu*, Tokyo: Heibon-sha, chap. 16. Translator's note: Agamben, G., ed., Hamacher, W., trans. Attel, K. (2004) *The Open: Man and Animal* (Crossing Aesthetics), California: Stanford Univ. Press, Chap. 16, pp. 75-77.

3: Rosalind Krauss points out how the dispersibility of light refers to Jaques Lacan's "gaze" and "the ambiguity of the jewel" (ambiguous as its glittering is faceted). Refer to her text for further analysis of Kito's work. I would like to add to this note that I owe the authors of this book for my insight in the matter of subjectivity and medium, which constitutes a central theme of this article. Bois, Y.A., & Krauss E., trans. by Kajiya, K., Kondo, M., Takakuwa, K. (2011) *Formless: A User's Guide*, Tokyo: Gersuyosha, pp. 265-285. English version: (1997), New York: Zone Books.

4: Didi-Huberman, G., trans. Suzuki, M. (1997) "Ikani shite ruiji wo hikisaku ka?" (How do we tear the resemblance?) In *Eureka* (Japanese journal) vol. 29, no. 9, p. 256. Original text: Didi-Huberman, G. (1995) "Comment déchirer-t-on la ressemblance?" In *Georges Bataille après tout*, Paris: Éditions Belin, pp. 101-123.

*Translator's note: The original French article was not accessible for reference. These quotations may not retain their original meaning, and contextual connotations may have been lost in the process of retranslation.

5: Ibid.

Translation : Koichiro Osaka

THE CIRCLE AS A METAPHORIC FORM

What does the exhibition title *The Echo* signify to us? Referring to the Greek myth of a nymph whose body faded and shrivelled to nothing more than her voice, what implications of this word are symbolically rendered here? *The Echo – Although I am still alive* at Kunstraum/Bethanien, in Kreuzberg, Berlin, marked the second chapter of the *Echo* series (the first shown under the same title at ZAIM Annex, Yokohama, Japan, 2008). Despite relocating to Germany and replacing several of the previous twenty-one artists, it nonetheless retained the original ethos. One may say that this inheritance has been promised since Haruka Ito, one of the organisers in 2008, described the show as a "resonator."*1 To me at least, the exhibition carried a sense of déjà-vu, perceived as a repetitive resonance despite the past four years of absence.

In this view, *The Echo* is like a ripple that expands in a concentric pattern: it self-generates iterable circles one after the next. The circle as a metaphoric form was imposed by the exhibition title. This stabilising gestalt gives a ripple effect to the artworks, even seeming to assimilate them into its wholeness. The traces and trails of this form of the exhibition – its repetitive pulse – run across all the exhibited works, as revealed in the physical appearance of the exhibition. For instance: Futo Akiyoshi's painting *Room* (2011) and Koichi Tabata's video work *fragment* (2008) are excerpts from continuing series that have been previously shown: for them, the exhibition served as an opportunity to reconfirm their artistic position. *The Echo* must be reviewed in light of its serial continuity and inclusiveness, within repetition and reverb that generate echoes.

The first *Echo* exhibition coincided with the 2008 Yokohama Triennale, and one would expect to see a revelation of a new sensitivity and the artistic views shared among members of the younger generations. Take for example the works of Kohei Nawa, Kengo Kito, and Daisuke Ohba: viewers were lured into extreme optical effects of reflected light through the use of acrylics and ore minerals. Some of these works were installed in white cubes, while others were screened on monitors glittering in the dark. These, through rational and experimental attempts by the artists, capture the viewer as if to forcibly expand his or her cognitive capacity by retinal impetus. These dazzling effects (as seen in the works of Kito and Akiyoshi) could also be seen in the sculptural work by Toshihiko Miyake, a gigantic construction: a life-size equestrian statue made of aluminium foil. In inverse relation to its overwhelming size and ostentatious display, the aluminium surface defuses light, obscuring the outline into a haunting ghost with no sense of gravity. In this way, the experience of *The Echo* is strictly bound to the different capacities of manufactured materials, each with varying degrees of plasticity and deformability (i.e., how brittle, elastic, and vicious it is). The viewer is overloaded with material information through visual perception, with an almost paralysing effect. It is this "quantitative" impact that continues to feed into *The Echo*'s repetitive cycle, which seemingly reasserts the visual's supremacy.

DEPRIVED SUBJECTIVITY

In response to our contemporary lives, preconditioned by information overload, the *Echo* artists in 2008 demonstrated a loose consensus on the positioning

of visual perception and its supremacy as a way of communication. This year saw a deliberate shift away from this visual emphasis, introduced mainly by new participants: Sako Kojima, Taro Izumi, and Meiro Koizumi. Izumi projected an image of his sleeping face, which puppets painted until it became entirely covered (*Steak House*, 2009). Looping a segment of Yasujiro Ozu's 1951 film *Early Summer*, Koizumi's live drawing performance traces the gradual occurrence of his sexual desire as he repeatedly mumbles a line by the heroine, Setsuko Hara (*Autopsychobabble* #2, 2011). Kojima disguises herself as a giant hamster acting out every detail of a small life confined in a cage (*The reason why I become hamster*, 2012). These works are self-referential, using the artist's body as a medium (in Izumi's case, as an alternative support medium), and defined by the singularity of the event. By objectifying their own body in the presence of the viewer, these artists escape the "quantitative" approach employed by their fellow artists.

I must note, however, that the very subjectivity that mobilises the body into action is placed in parentheses. In these works, the body is a passive agent continuing its motion through inertia, there is an automisation of bodily action without resorting to the power of subjectivity. Intermittent flashes of consciousness on Izumi's sleeping face symbolise this notion of de-subjectification. The same applies to Kojima: "unexpected" actions in her performance are not abrupt and contingent but rather are programmed through sequential patterns of behaviour. In this regard, one may recall Giorgio Agamben's remark on "the unconditional unfolding of the oikonomia . . . as the supreme political (or rather apolitical) task," where "the total humanisation of the animal coincides with a total animalisation of man."*2 Kojima, in her performance, does not set a clear target out of "bio-power"; instead, she silently signals her intention in the fissure of rationality, doubling her own image as an irrational being.

Koizumi's *Autopsychobabble* #2 (2011), as the title suggests, conjures images of the babble-like mutterings in necromancy or a spirit possession as a temporal deprivation of one's subjectivity. In this psychological duality, Koizumi turns his amorous eyes on an iconic Japanese actress, Setsuko Hara, known as the "eternal virgin," who, at the time of WWII, played an active role in fuelling the national spirit. Koizumi, driven by his phallic desire, daringly and importunately traces the actress's figure as if attempting intercourse: but all in vain. The paper is torn by the pressure of his hand and his sexual desire shattered in misery. Repeated failure and the impossibility of intercourse in the presence of viewers are at the core of his performance, and entail a never-successful attempt at the creation and destruction of his "autonomic" form. In short, it is a self-destructive form in which his libidinal desire fails in the representation of the actress.

DISTORTED FORM

Hidden behind these works (by Izumi, Kojima, and Koizumi) is the construction of a medium that utterly destroys all forms within and violates the realm of subjectivity. This is present even in the works that can be rationally scrutinised – works in which excess information is encapsulated in the governing material structure. Nobuhiko Murayama's *from a distance*

– *plant, person, fighter* (2012), is painted from the back of the canvas and deformed into an image obscured like a receding memory. Here again is the threatening violence of a medium that wrests the artist from his subjective control: subjectivity is outstripped by the force of a medium leaving itself in the fertility of repetition.

Clichéd criticism of *The Echo* – being rational and "cool," politically naive, lacking social awareness, closed and self-satisfactory – overlooks this crucial point: *The Echo*'s approach is existential in its quiet struggle for a new medium, with materialisation and subjectivity exposed to violence. Kengo Kito's *Untitled (Hula-Hoop)* (2012) is not a simple, stable loop structure of hula-hoops joined together. Destined to endless repetition, its fluid circulation runs at increasing speed across all directions as if to risk throwing its structure out of balance. Signature attributes of Kito's past work, such as the decentred structure and overly decorative surface, are there to implode the stabilising gestalt of the form they outline.*3

Yet there emerges a form of resistance among the *Echo* artists against this circular, ring-like structure; as in Akiyoshi's space partition (*Room*, 2011) and Tabata's spider with long, skinny legs (*fragment*, 2008). Like the radiating lines from Koizumi's eyes in his portrait, this takes a form of one-point perspective converging on a vanishing point. Employing the law of perspective to create the illusion of three-dimensional reality can be thought institutional and may provoke biases of being secluded in inward-facing academicism. However, in these works, the radially expanding presentation blurs the line between figure and ground, as well as visualising the distance between the gazed at object and the self, thus opening a fissure in which new forms of creation may be spawned.

Georges Didi-Huberman, in his remarks in *Documents* (1929–30), a surrealist magazine edited by Georges Bataille, described Bataille's approach to sorting images "classification disorder*": by transgressing artistic idealism and denying high and low in their value hierarchy, Bataille, with his notion of "base materialism," sorted images figuratively according to their formal resemblances. This may appear to be an anti-aesthetic deconstruction, but in it Didi-Huberman finds an active engagement that Bataille "interweaves" at the same time as he "tears" apart the classification by "something that looks alike [bold sic]."*4 Huberman continues: "let one form assault another and let one devour another . . ."*5 It is this chaotic disorder of "declassified" forms that provides an insight into *The Echo*'s strategy, which prevails throughout the exhibition.

The exhibition *The Echo* embraces structural repetition within its form. It also embraces a dynamism in which stabilising repetition is interfered with and disturbed by multiplying forms and concepts. Huberman's remark – "let one form assault another and let one devour another . . ." – may well describe Kojima's performance: biting off paper into pieces only for her survival's sake is itself an act that produces irregular fragments of form. His remark also points to Tabata's spider which tears apart its own image in a hand-drawn animated sequence (931 *daddy long-legs spider*, 2012). These are only traces of the artists' existential and aesthetic pursuit – a revolt against repetition.

Courage to Carry On: The Echo in Berlin

Alexander Hofmann

Curator, *Arts of Japan*
Asian Art Museum, National Museums in Berlin

Ranging from at first glance rather conventional paintings and sculptures to mixed-media installations and performances, the art works in the exhibition *The Echo – Although I am still alive* defy any unifying classification in terms of style, technique, format, or media. And although all of the exhibiting artists hail from Japan, none of them appears interested in playing up to Euro-American notions of Japaneseness. They are also not united by a common place of birth, shared experiences at an educational institution, or allegiance to a charismatic teacher as is so often the case in the more conservative circles of the Japanese art establishment even today. Quite a number of visitors might thus have wondered what the *raison d'être* for this group show of artists of the younger generation from Japan might have been. A simple answer might reference the history of the group *The Echo* which started out on the occasion of the 2008 Yokohama Triennale as a kind of Salon des Refusés, a platform for the generation of artists born circa 1975–1980 with some elder or younger participants joining in. They form a loose network, quite similar to the decentred organisation of current social media circles, informed in their case not so much by a common vision as by mutual respect for the honesty and devotion with which they pursue their work. However, their art shares several characteristic attitudes which are not expressively articulated but have to be inferred.

In striking contrast to the superflat artists of the so-called Tokyo (Neo-)Pop movement, such as Takashi Murakami or Yoshitomo Nara, who have been tremendously successful in the global art market until quite recently with their easily consumable, self-orientalising concoctions which cannibalise the seemingly exotic, frequently erotic imagery of Japanese popular culture media like manga and anime, the *Echo* artists seldom employ markers of national identity. Quite a number of them have studied, lived, or are currently still based outside Japan. Works by two of them reflect on their respective transcultural experiences. Berlin-based Toshihiko Mitsuya alludes in his sculpture of a knight on horseback made from aluminium foil to Albrecht Dürer's etching *Ritter, Tod und Teufel* (Knight, Death, and Devil) of 1513. While the title *Anonymous relatives* – guide appears to pay homage to a famous artist of his host country, the darkish subject matter might also allude to the tragic events in the north-eastern region of his native Japan, also referenced in the subtitle of this exhibition. On the other hand, Kei Takemura, who likewise lives and works in Berlin, stitches herself unto the context of "transplantation" in her mixed-media work that combines black-and-white photographs of "native" palm trees in Los Angeles and "imported ones" in Nagoya superposed with drawings and embroidery of a palm tree on translucent cloth.

With the notable exceptions of Sako Kojima and Taro Izumi, most *Echo* artists steer away not only from expressions of national identity but also from bigger social issues and the spirit of art as activism which is germane both to the critical, at times even cynical stance of the artists of The Group 1965 (Makoto Aida, Sumihisa Arima, Parco Kinoshita, Hiroyuki Matsukage, Oscar Oiwa, and Tsuyoshi Ozawa) – which was finally introduced to German audiences in 2011 via a group show at Kunsthalle Düsseldorf – and the questioning of transcultural, social, and gender hierarchies and identities by Japanese photographers and mixed-media artists ranging from Yasumasa Morimura,

Miwa Yanagi, and others in the 1990s to Tomoko Sawada, Yuki Onodera, and Ryudai Takano among others more recently. The *Echo* artists focus instead on personal experiences, concerns, and expressions. They engage with formal issues – for example: Akiyoshi Futo's explorations of space and the materiality of golden oil paint on the two-dimensional field of the canvas or Kengo Kito's three-dimensional installations of ordinary objects – or they visualise personal, occasionally fantastic worlds (Keiko Kimoto, Kentaro Kobuke, Takeshi Makishima, and Shingo Yoshida).

Frail reminiscences, the construction of memory, and the after-life of images as well as metamorphosis-like transformations from one media to another are a recurring topic. Meiro Koizumi, for example, interlaces what appear to be nostalgic video images from Japan's past with his commentary and the painter Nobuhiko Murayama painstakingly depicts images gleaned from the mass media on glass panes which are subsequently in turn transferred to the back of canvases resulting in barely perceptible images. Takahiro Ueda investigates shifts from audio to visual information through his manipulations of meteorological data from weather satellites while Kouichi Tabata incorporates drawings animation-style into a video that oscillates between still and moving images.

Sociologist-cum-art-critic Adrian Favell demonstrated in 2008 in his contribution for the publication published on the occasion of the *Echo* exhibition in Yokohama that the conscious choice of media, almost craft-like labour-intensive finish of ordinary or sustainable materials – perhaps best exemplified by Satoru Aoyama's embroidered paintings – as well as the focus on personal subject matter is related to the *Echo* artists' experience of a Japanese society that has for the last two decades been facing tremendous competition from neighbouring countries, economic and social stagnation, and ecological problems. Reluctance to engage with current social and political conditions in Japan in an abstract or analytical way might thus reflect a distrust of the meta-narratives of politics and corporate Japan. The frustrating experience of this lingering crisis is, however, addressed in some works in the exhibition.

Sako Kojima's *The reason why I become hamster*, performed by the costumed artist in a cage-like environment of her own construction in the midst of the exhibition space, besides playing with the voyeuristic and exhibitionist

impulses involved in all performance art, presents a ruthless metaphor for life in Japan as a brutal treadmill. A somewhat more humorous approach is taken by Taro Izumi. He filmed himself painting with a pole which had colour pencils attached on both ends. Simultaneously creating images on the floor and the walls, he thus presented the act of representation itself as an absurd game which results in a multitude of fractured images, in a rare display of self-ironic humour.

While most of the *Echo* artists continue to speak to us of their personal experiences and visions in rather low, almost restrained voices and the post-national character of their work appears to be at odds with the format of an exhibition of artists from Japan, the very multitude or disparity of expressions by this network paints a more accurate picture of the state of contemporary art in Japan than any conventional group exhibition ever could. Without doubt some of the artists will go on to present their work to larger audiences in solo shows while others might enjoy only short-lived careers. Used as we are to the cynical stance of most contemporary artists, we cannot but admire the earnestness with which these young artists from Japan pursue their visions and their courage to carry on in spite of all circumstances.

Kojima Sako

P. 34 — 35

(b.1976)

The reason why I become hamster, 2012, performance

Kojima draws, paints, sculpts, and performs the life of a hamster as a caricatured city dweller whose life is helplessly formulated into the daily routine of work-eat-sleep. Locked up in a gallery cell, and under the surveillance of visitors, Kojima mindlessly continues her habitual behaviours – biting sunflower seeds and chewing on paper – for almost a week: it is a confrontation with the fears of inescapable boredom and solitude in life, executed in a bright spirit of optimism.

Makishima Takeshi

P. 36 — 37

(b.1980)

Apostrophe, 2012, acrylic, oil on linen, 183 × 214 cm

Makishita's canvas is an escapist sanctuary charged with phantasmagorical scenery, such as a procession of animals moving through the forest or a circle of villagers collapsed around a house of cards. Employing theatrical narratives, Makishita opens an imaginary gap between fiction and reality and injects an enigmatic world of allegory that retrospectively rewrites its symbolic representations and rhetoric.

Mitsuya Toshihiko

P. 38 — 39

(b.1979)

Anonymous relatives – guide, 2012, aluminium foil, 420 × 250 × 120 cm

Mitsuya's practice is an investigation into material potentials of aluminium foil. Having collaborated with architects testing its durability in various forms of construction, Mitsuya created a life-size equestrian statue made of aluminium foil to resemble Albrecht Dürer's masterpiece etching. The work was publicly displayed in the city of Berlin, initiating transcultural dialogues with many passers-by.

Murayama Nobuhiko

P. 40 — 41

(b.1980)

From a distance – plant, person, fighter, 2012, oil, watercolour, linen, wood, 160 × 120 cm, 160 × 120 cm, 160 × 120 cm

Murayama applies colour pigments to the back of hemp canvas. Paint is filtered through fine canvas mesh attaining pointillistic appearance and emerges to the surface as a faint, discoloured projection of distant memory. In these "reverse" paintings, the process of image filtering intervenes into the viewer's experience, weaving a spell of nostalgia as if a memory were gradually receding into the grainy haze of the past.

Tabata Kouichi

P. 42 — 43

(b.1979)

931 daddy long-legs spider, 2012, HD video projection, loop, a set of 931 pieces of the original A4 drawings, dimension variable

Tabata's practice borders on two media: drawing and animation. Hand-drawing up to 1000 stills or as many as his pen holds its ink, Tabata produces scrupulous works of understatement, in a radical opposition to his predecessors' "self-centred" aesthetics. Occurrences in his video are so subtle and discreet as to be almost unrecognisable. Tabata cordially asks the viewer to approach closer to his work "like you listen to someone whispering."

Takemura Kei

P. 44 — 45

(b.1975)

They're still alive in both cities, 2012, Japanese silk thread, synthetic cloth, black-and-white print on paper, 400 × 410 cm

Personal memory, of herself and of anonymous others, is at the core of Takemura's practice. Mediated by found objects as relics and mementos, and with a frequent use of translucent silk thread as a gesture of never-to-fade preservation of the past, Takemura composes quiet poetry of the everyday to *comme-morare* all ephemeral beings that are no longer present.

Ueda Takahiro

P. 46 — 47

(b.1986)

Track of At(o)m, 2012, monitor, PC, printer, 137MHz-QFH aerial, receiver, aluminium, wood

Ueda poses a question and creates a physical framework to respond to it: it is his outright curiosity that provides a strong base for his practice. His most recent interest was a weather aerial that receives signals only when the satellite passes directly above the current location. Catching live metrological data and simultaneously encoding it onto the screen, Ueda reflected on the togetherness of those present and here and now in the gallery space through digital technology of satellite viewing.

Yoshida Shingo

P. 48 — 49

(b.1974)

SOLON B comme Berlin, 2012, monitor, mirror, chair, travel documents

Yoshida's work is centred on the existentialist question of being; his enquiries into identity, misplacement, and disintegration of himself in and out of specific cultural and geographical contexts are a natural part of this investigation. Yoshida produces a prolific amount of photographic and video work documenting his own extensive journeys "as if he is playing hide-and-seek in the world alone – while hiding himself, he seeks the hidden."

* Japanese names are presented as surname followed by forename.

[Exhibition]

THE ECHO - Although I am still alive -

Period : August 10 - 27, 2012

Venue : Kunstraum Kreuzberg Bethanien, Berlin, Germany

Organized by *The Echo* Committee

Organized under the auspices of the Japanese Embassy
in Germany and the Japanese-German Center Berlin
Supported by the Nomura Cultural Foundation,
the Asahi Shimbun Foundation and the Japan Foundation
In cooperation with Michiko Ogura (Art Engineers)

Directors : Nobuhiko Murayama, Kengo Kito, Kiyohide Hayashi

Art Director : Rua Kawase



[Talk + Performance]

"JAPAN NEXT - Japanese Artists in the Flow of Contemporary Art"

Period : August 23, 2012

Organized by *The Echo* Committee + the Japanese-German Center Berlin

Performance : *Feedback to Backfeed* by Takehito Koganezawa

Talk 1 : "Now and Then, Here and There"

Guest Speakers : Katja Blomberg (Director, Haus am Waldsee),
Claudia Delank (Independent curator, Director at Galerie Claudia Delank),
Alexander Hofmann (Curator, Arts of Japan, Asian Art Museum, Berlin)

Talk 2 : "Looking Back to the Future"

Guest Speakers : Kei Takemura, Kengo Kito, Nobuhiko Murayama,
Katja Blomberg, Claudia Delank, Alexander Hofmann

Chair : Carsten Probst (Independent writer and critic)

[Catalogue]

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